ney to Persia. "It's one of the most beautiful Mughal helmets I have seen in my life," says Nanda.

The genealogy of the Mughal dynasty is represented through their coins, including one minted by Akbar—one of the rarest Mughal coins, which says 'Allahu Akbar Jalla Jalaluhu' on one side and 'Ram' on the other. It was quite an adventure sourcing all the coins, which is perhaps why this is Nanda's favourite corner of the museum.

The star exhibit, however, is undoubtedly the original finial of Humayun's Tomb dating from 1570 which collapsed in a sandstorm in 2014. (A replica was subsequently installed on the dome.) "The spheres of the golden finial or *kalash* were pancaked. Metallurgy conservation experts from around the world had ruled out any possibility of a restoration," says Nanda, "but a *thathera* (coppersmith) from Chandni Chowk, with little tools and a lot of patience, fixed it over a period of two years." The 18-foot-tall finial is what determined the height of the museum building.

This encouraging nudge to India's living crafts is very much part of the museum's sustainable development agenda and can be seen throughout the galleries in recreated or specially commissioned objects, from the 1:50 architectural models of the monuments to the replica mother-of-pearl canopy of Nizamuddin Dargah, elegant stone lattices, the conical turban—Taj-i-Izzat—that Humayun fashioned for himself, and, most spectacularly, in the life-size recreations of the ceilings of key monuments in incised lime plaster which grace the museum's walls. A house of wonders, the museum will give visitors fresh eyes with which to view Humayun's Tomb and the Nizamuddin Conservation Area. ■

–Amit Dixit

THEATRE

CAPITAL DRAMA

The fifth edition of the Delhi Theatre Festival promises a galaxy of star performers

The Delhi Theatre Festival is returning for its fifth edition in the capital city from September 20 to 22. Four venues in Delhi NCR–Kamani Auditorium, Siri Fort Auditorium, OP Jindal Auditorium and Orana Conventions (Gurugram)–will host a total of seven plays across these three days. Celebrated veterans of the stage like Naseeruddin Shah, Lilette Dubey, Vinay Pathak et al will perform during the festival being organised by Alchemist LIVE, an entertainment firm.

Naseeruddin and Ratna Pathak Shah will be seen in the Russian playwright Aleksei Arbuzov's 1977 play *Old World*. It had opened the Prithvi Theatre Festival in Mumbai last year to much acclaim. The story follows an introverted doctor at a health resort who meets an unconventional woman, and how this coincidental meeting changes their lives. Twinkle Khanna's *Salaam Noni Aapa* and Shabana Azmi's *Broken Images* will also be staged.

Other performances include *One On One Dhamaal*, a series of nine short monologues written and performed by various actors in Hindi and English. Vrajesh Hirjee performs a monologue called 'Game Set(ting) and Match' (written by Farhad Sorabjee and directed by Rajit Kapur) about a Gujarati NRI who comes to India. Talking about the play, Hirjee says, "It is about an NRI boy who is in search of a bride for himself. But along the way, he gets distracted because he also has a business project that he feels shows promise in the Indian context–I can't tell you the nature of the business because that would be a spoiler!"

Four venues in Delhi NCR will host a total of seven plays from Sept. 20 to 22

The 53-year-old Hirjee has been a mainstay of stage and screen in India for over two decades now. Having made his debut in the 1998 film adaptation of the Rohinton Mistry novel *Such a Long Journey*, Hirjee is known for his dynamic supporting roles in blockbusters like *Kaho Naa Pyaar Hai* (2000) and the three *Golmaal* movies (2006-2017). He is also a widely-lauded theatre actor, known for productions like the satire *Guards at the Taj* (2017), written by Rajiv Joseph and directed by Danish Husain.

"Theatre is where an actor really hones his craft in real time," Hirjee says. "It's like a viva, almost. There are hundreds of examiners looking up at you, and as an actor you're constantly being informed about their interest levels. It's challenging but it's also very rewarding." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha



CURTAIN CALL
(Left) Naseeruddin Shah and Ratna Pathak Shah in *Old World*, (below) Vrajesh Hirjee